01. The Overcoat – Summary (Easy 10-Mark Answer)

About the Author

Nikolai Gogol (1809–1852) was a Russian writer known for his satirical and humorous style. His works often criticize social injustice and bureaucracy in Russia.

Summary

The Overcoat is one of Nikolai Gogol's most famous short stories. It tells the tragic and touching story of Akaky Akakievich, a poor government clerk in St. Petersburg. Through his life, Gogol highlights the problems of poverty, social injustice, and the cruelty of the bureaucratic system.

Akaky Akakievich is a simple and innocent man who works as a copyist. He has no interest in anything except copying official documents. His life is very dull and lonely, and he is regularly mocked by his colleagues. He accepts all insults quietly without complaining, which shows his helplessness and gentle nature. He earns very little money and lives in extreme poverty.

The main event of the story begins when Akaky's old overcoat becomes completely worn out. The winter in St. Petersburg is harsh, and he desperately needs a warm coat. When the tailor Petrovich tells him that the coat cannot be repaired and he must get a new one, Akaky becomes worried because he cannot afford it. However, he decides to save money by cutting down his expenses. For months, he sacrifices small comforts such as food, candles, and tea. His determination shows how important the overcoat becomes in his life.

When the new overcoat is finally made, it brings Akaky great joy. His colleagues admire it and even throw a small celebration in his honour. For the first time, he feels noticed and respected. But this happiness does not last long. On the night of the celebration, two thieves steal his overcoat.

Akaky tries to seek help from the police and even approaches a high-ranking official, but no one helps him. The "Important Person" even scolds him harshly, which shocks Akaky deeply.

The loss of the overcoat breaks his spirit. He falls sick and dies soon after. Later, his ghost appears on the streets, taking overcoats from others, including the Important Person. This supernatural ending symbolizes society's guilt.

Gogol uses Akaky's tragic life to criticize the insensitivity of society and the corruption of officials. He shows that even a small act of kindness could save a life, while cruelty can destroy a person completely. The story reminds us of the importance of compassion and human dignity.

Themes

a) Poverty and Struggle, b) Social Injustice, c) Human Dignity, d) Bureaucracy and Power Abuse, e) Supernatural Element.

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR

II. Character Sketch of Akaky Akakievich Bashmachkin

Akaky Akakievich is the central character of Nikolai Gogol's The Overcoat. He is a poor government clerk who works as a copyist. His life is simple and monotonous. He enjoys copying documents and finds peace in his work. Akaky has no friends, no family, and no social life, which shows his lonely existence.

He is extremely humble, shy, and gentle. He never argues with anyone, even when his colleague's insult or mock him. Instead of reacting, he quietly continues his work. This shows his patience and innocent nature. He is also honest and hardworking, but his sincerity is not appreciated in the office.

Akaky lives in poverty. His clothes are old, his room is bare, and he eats very little because he earns a very small salary. His old overcoat becomes a big problem in the cold winter. When he decides to buy a new one, it becomes the only excitement of his life. His dedication to saving every small coin for the overcoat shows his determination and sacrifice.

The new overcoat brings Akaky rare moments of joy and respect. For the first time, his colleagues notice him and treat him kindly. But this happiness is short-lived, as the overcoat is stolen, and Akaky receives no help from the officials. The loss leads to his emotional breakdown and death.

Akaky's character symbolizes the suffering of the poor and the cruelty of society. Through him, Gogol shows how an ordinary, harmless man can be destroyed by neglect and injustice.

III. Character Sketch of Petrovich (the tailor)

Petrovich is the tailor who stitche Akaky's new overcoat. He is an important minor character in the story. He is described as a skilled but moody tailor. He often drinks, which affects his behaviour, and sometimes he argues with his customers.

When Akaky brings his old overcoat for repair, Petrovich honestly explains that it cannot be fixed and a new one must be made. This shows that he is straightforward and practical. He charges a high amount for stitching the overcoat, which seems unfair, but it also reflects the economic condition of the time and the exploitation faced by the poor.

Despite his rough behaviour, Petrovich completes the overcoat with great care. The new overcoat becomes a symbol of hope and happiness in Akaky's life. Petrovich's role is small but meaningful because he indirectly brings the only joy that Akaky experiences.

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR

IV. Themes in The Overcoat

Nikolai Gogol's The Overcoat is not only a story about a poor clerk and his stolen coat; it is a powerful work rich in themes that criticise society, expose human suffering, and highlight the need for compassion. The story deals with several major themes such as poverty, social injustice, bureaucratic cruelty, human dignity, and the supernatural.

One of the strongest themes in the story is poverty. Akaky Akakievich lives a life of extreme hardship. His salary is so small that even buying a new overcoat becomes a life-changing struggle. Gogol shows how poverty traps people and forces them to sacrifice their basic needs. Akaky's months of saving and suffering for a simple coat represent the harsh reality of the lower class.

Another important theme is social injustice and cruelty. Throughout the story, Akaky is ignored, insulted, and mistreated. His colleagues mock him for their entertainment, and no one supports him. Society sees him as insignificant because he is poor. Even when his overcoat is stolen, the authorities show no concern. This highlights how the poor are often denied justice and respect.

The story also criticises the bureaucratic system. The "Important Person" represents the arrogance of those in power. Instead of helping Akaky, he scolds him and uses his position to show superiority. Gogol mocks the Russian bureaucracy by showing how officials care more about their status than the people they are supposed to serve.

A key thematic idea in the story is human dignity. For Akaky, the overcoat is not just a piece of clothing; it is a symbol of hope, confidence, and respect. The way people treat him differently after he gets the new coat shows how society values appearance more than character. When the coat is taken away, Akaky loses all dignity and hope, which leads to his death.

Finally, the supernatural element at the end adds a symbolic theme. Akaky's ghost stealing overcoats shows the return of justice in a dark, ironic way. It suggests that the cruelty and neglect of society do not disappear—they come back to haunt the guilty.

Through these themes, Gogol reveals the pain of ordinary people and teaches the importance of kindness, empathy, and humanity.

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR

https://youtu.be/Wihxgz-h9-A?si=aXdNSHyX53nctXi2

*****

02. Kirubunkal – Long Answer (10 Marks)

"Kirubunkal," written by Dr. Ravikumar Neha, is a powerful story that combines reality, imagination, village gossip, and human psychology. The story exposes how rumours and false tales can destroy families and disturb the cultural harmony of a community. It also highlights how modern technology and changing values affect relationships.

The story revolves around Seena (Sreenivasa), a careless young man who is addicted to mobile phones and reels. He compares his dark-skinned wife with the fair and attractive girls he watches online, which shows the influence of unrealistic digital images on the minds of today's youth. Seena's parents, Eeri and Mudli, represent hardworking rural people who struggle to maintain dignity in society.

The turning point of the story is the mysterious death of Mudli, who is found dead near Chandranna's farm. No one knows the truth, but villagers quickly invent their own versions of the story. Every person adds imagination and turns the incident into gossip. Some say Mudli insulted Chandranna's family; some accuse him of an affair; others blame Chandranna for murder. These rumours show how society enjoys lies more than truth.

An interesting and unique feature of the story is that the tales themselves become characters. They complain that human beings no longer create meaningful stories based on experience, but only spread lies, dirty jokes, and sensational rumours. The tales decide to take revenge by creating even more confusing stories that make society unstable.

The Kirubunkal tree, an ancient and sacred tree, symbolizes the traditional culture of storytelling. It observes how human values are declining and warns that society is slowly losing kindness, unity, and truthfulness.
Through these elements, "Kirubunkal" teaches that rumours can destroy lives, technology must be used responsibly, and traditional storytelling should be protected. The story encourages readers to think critically, to respect truth, and to preserve moral values in society.

Themes in the story: 1. Theme of Rumour, Gossip, and False Tales,
2. Dehumanisation in Modern Society, 3. Caste, Class, and Oppression,
4. Corruption of Traditional Culture, 5. Symbolism of Kirubunkal,
6. Breakdown of Moral and Social Values, 7. Psychological Decline of Seena.

Conclusion: Kirubunkal is not just a story about a village—It is a critique of the entire modern world, where: truth is replaced by lies, culture is replaced by cheap entertainment, technology controls human minds, caste and power destroy justice, and old storytelling traditions are dying. Through powerful symbols and raw language, the story warns that unless society changes, both humans and their culture will continue to collapse.

AMBEDKAR COLLHR

II. Short Notes on for 05/10 marks

1. Seena's Obsession in Life

Seena grows up as a lonely and confused young man after the mysterious death of his father, Mudli. Raised by his mother Eeri, he develops an unhealthy attachment to his mobile phone. Instead of involving himself in real life, relationships, or responsibilities, Seena spends all his time watching reels, videos of beautiful girls, and pornographic content. This makes him dissatisfied with his dark-skinned wife Shalini and even with himself. His obsession with fair skin and beauty leads him to constantly wash his face, hoping to become fair. The phone becomes his escape from reality, and he stops caring about family, marriage, or village life. He behaves like a child even after marriage, sharing intimate details of his life openly. Seena's obsession symbolises how technology and fantasy distance young people from reality, pushing them into illusion and irresponsibility.

2. Indian Tradition of Telling Tales

The story highlights the rich Indian tradition of storytelling, where tales—called "kathe" or "stories"—become part of the community's living culture. In the village, tales are not just entertainment; they shape beliefs, identity, and collective memory. Elders like Hirikateyajji carried these tales from one generation to another, giving life to nature, people, and culture. Tales travelled across villages, changing form over time, mixing truth and imagination. They explained strange events, moral issues, and social relations. However, in Kirubunkal, the sacred tradition weakens. Modern influences, false rumours, and sensational stories replace meaningful tales. Instead of wisdom, tales start spreading fear, lust, division, and lies. Through talking tales and mythical elements, the story shows how India's storytelling heritage once guided society but is now threatened by misinformation and loss of values.

3. Eeri's Life After Mudli's Death

After Mudli's mysterious and violent death, Eeri's life becomes filled with hardship and loneliness. As a widow, she must raise Seena single-handedly. She deeply loves her son because he is the only memory of her dead husband. Eeri works hard to fulfil all of Seena's wishes, even buying him a mobile phone, hoping it will make him happy. She hopes for government compensation after Mudli's death, but it never arrives, adding to her worries. Her life becomes centered entirely around caring for Seena, who gradually becomes irresponsible and mentally unstable. Later, she arranges Seena's marriage to Shalini, hoping marriage will bring stability, but Seena continues his unhealthy habits. Eeri silently suffers as village tales accuse her of immoral relationships, damaging her dignity. Her life represents the struggles of widows in rural India, who face poverty, gossip, and emotional burden without any support.

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR

4. Attack on Mudli

Mudli's death forms the central mystery of Kirubunkal. On the dark night of the new moon, when he goes searching for his missing son Seena, he hears strange cries and moves towards Kirabunkal. Later that night, he is attacked by a group of men—followers of Sahukar Chandranna. They beat him brutally, leaving him speechless and half-dead. The reason for the attack is unclear, but many contradictory tales spread across the village: some claim Mudli had an affair with Chandranna's wife, others say he misbehaved with Chandranna's daughter Vimli, and some say Chandranna was involved with Eeri. These tales create multiple possibilities, showing how truth gets buried under rumours. Mudli collapses near Chandranna's farm and dies. His death becomes the starting point for new tales, gossip, and fear in the village. The attack symbolises violence caused by caste politics, rumours, and power imbalance.

5. Importance of Hirikateyajji

Hirikateyajji is portrayed as the oldest and most respected elder among the "tales." She represents wisdom, tradition, and the ancient storytelling culture of the village. While the other tales begin to spread sensational, immoral, and harmful stories, Hirikateyajji recognises the danger these new tales pose to society. She speaks with authority and concern, reminding the tales of their original duty—to guide humans, bring harmony, and create meaningful stories. Her warnings express the fear that the village is losing its moral compass. She also approaches Kirabunkal, the sacred origin of tales, seeking solutions to restore the village's lost values. Through her character, the text conveys the message that elders and traditional knowledge are necessary to maintain balance in society. Hirikateyajji becomes a symbolic grandmother figure who tries to protect culture from being destroyed by modern distortions and irresponsible storytelling.

6. Importance of Sahukar Chandranna

Sahukar Chandranna is an influential and powerful figure in the village. His presence shapes many events in the story, especially the mysterious death of Mudli. Several tales revolve around him—some accuse him of having an affair with Eeri, others say Mudli was involved with his wife or daughter, and some tales even imply he killed Mudli to protect his family's honour. Although the real truth is never known, Chandranna's social status allows him to manipulate narratives and hide facts.

He uses the village's fear during the sickness outbreak to claim Mudli died of disease, quickly burying him without proper rituals. This makes him a symbol of how people in power can control stories, spread misinformation, and influence public belief. Chandranna represents authority, fear, and the role of upper-class men in shaping the fate of weaker families like Eeri's. His character exposes the injustice in rural power structures.

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR.

7. The Tales of the Village

In Kirubunkal, tales are personified as living beings who move through the village, interact with each other, and influence human lives. Earlier, tales were meaningful, moral, and imaginative, giving life to the land and shaping cultural identity. They helped people understand their world. But over time, the tales change. They become sensational, vulgar, and harmful—focusing on rumours, sexual fantasies, and false accusations. They confuse truth and lies, causing fear, conflict, and misunderstanding among the villagers. The death of Mudli becomes a fertile ground for new tales to be born every day. These tales invade the lives of Mudli, Eeri, Chandranna, and Vimli, destroying their dignity. The text shows how stories can uplift society or corrupt it, depending on how they are used. The village becomes a factory of false storytelling, reflecting today's world of misinformation and viral content.

8. Morality and the Village Tales

The story highlights how village tales shape the community's morality. Earlier, tales carried wisdom, ethical lessons, and respect for nature and people. They preserved cultural values. However, in the modern context of the story, morality collapses. Tales no longer teach good behaviour; instead, they spread lies, lust, and violence. They distort reality to entertain people, satisfying hidden desires rather than guiding them. False narratives lead to moral chaos in the village—people judge Eeri, imagine sinful affairs, and gossip without concern for truth. Men fantasize about women mentioned in tales, and women fear for their safety and dignity. The tales show how morality weakens when a community loses empathy, responsibility, and truth. Through this shift, the author criticizes how modern society replaces genuine stories with corruption, fake news, and sensational gossip, leading to the decline of social values.

9. The Village Life in 'Kirubunkal'

Village life in Kirubunkal is portrayed as a mix of tradition, poverty, superstition, and gossip. The village depends heavily on stories and rumours to understand events, especially mysterious ones like Mudli's death. People's lives are deeply influenced by caste hierarchy, economic inequality, and social expectations. Technology, like mobile phones, has entered village life but distorted values—for example, Seena becomes addicted to reels and adult content. The community is quick to suspect and judge others, creating false stories about relationships and scandals. Villagers live in fear during sickness outbreaks, showing their vulnerability. Nature also suffers; Kirabunkal, the life-giving tree, weakens due to human neglect. The village survives through oral tales, celebrations, and old customs, but it is slowly collapsing under modern pressures and the spread of harmful gossip. The story reveals both the charm and the dark side of rural Indian life.

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR

10. Indian Ethos and Folktale

Kirubunkal reflects core Indian ethos through its deep connection with folktales, communal storytelling, nature, and moral lessons. Indian culture traditionally views storytelling as a sacred art that teaches values, preserves heritage, and strengthens community bonds. The personification of tales and Kirabunkal, the ancient tree, highlights the Indian belief that nature and stories hold spiritual power. Folktales often mix the real and the supernatural, just as the story blends everyday life with mythical elements. The text also reflects Indian ethos through themes like respect for elders, social hierarchy, belief in destiny, and the importance of preserving truth. However, the story also critiques the loss of this ethos in modern times. When tales turn immoral or misleading, society loses direction. Thus, Kirubunkal shows both the richness of Indian folktale tradition and the danger of forgetting its original purpose—guiding people toward wisdom and harmony.

III. Explain the significance of Kirubankal as the controlling entity of the village. (10 Marks)

In the story Kirubunkal, Kirubankal is not just a physical place or a tree; it is presented as the life-force and guardian of the entire village. It functions like a controlling spirit that watches over the people, their stories, and the balance of life. For generations, Kirubankal has given birth to tales, protected the village, and maintained harmony between nature and humans.
The villagers believed that even the rain, wind, clouds, and sunlight entered the village only with the permission of Kirubankal. This shows that Kirubankal had a powerful symbolic authority, acting like a moral and natural regulator.

Kirubankal also represents tradition, memory, culture, and truth. Earlier, the tales that came from Kirubankal were pure, meaningful, and life-giving. They united the community and helped people understand right and wrong. However, with the arrival of modern changes—mobile phones, fake stories, sensationalism, and moral decline—Kirubankal becomes weak and powerless. This symbolizes the collapse of traditional wisdom.

When Hirikateyajji begs Kirubankal to save the village from false tales, Kirubankal speaks like a tired elder who has seen centuries of change. Kirubankal expresses sadness because people no longer respect nature, truth, or the elders. It complains that humans have become selfish, careless, and disconnected from the natural world.

Thus, Kirubankal is significant because it represents the soul of the village, the centre of its stories, the guardian of its moral values, and the symbol of a harmonious relationship between humans and nature. Its decline reflects the decay of the entire community.

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR

IV. How does the narrative voice express deep concerns about village life in the story Kirubunkal? (10 Marks)

The narrative voice in Kirubunkal expresses powerful concerns about the moral, social, cultural, and environmental decay in the village. Through the dialogues of characters like Hirikateyajji, Kirubankal, and the personified tales, the story highlights how traditional life has been damaged by modern habits, false beliefs, and irresponsible behaviour.

One major concern expressed is the disappearance of meaningful stories. Earlier, tales gave life, unity, and wisdom to the village. But now, no one listens to stories, and only sensational, vulgar, and destructive tales spread. The narrative shows how false rumours about Eeri, Chandranna, Vimli, and Mudli destroy the dignity of individuals and create division among caste groups.

Another concern is the breakdown of human relationships, especially seen through Seena's addiction to mobile reels and pornography. The story criticizes how technology is destroying family bonds, human values, and self-respect. Seena forgets his responsibilities, mocks his wife, and behaves like a child, showing the emotional emptiness of modern life.

The narrative also criticizes violence, exploitation, caste hierarchies, and injustice. Mudli's mysterious death, the false accusations, and the beating he receives reveal the power of the upper classes and the helplessness of the poor.

A deep anxiety about environmental destruction is also expressed. Kirubankal, once strong and sacred, is now dying due to human greed, pollution, and neglect. This symbolizes the destruction of nature and the loss of cultural roots.

Finally, the narrative voice expresses fear about the future. It shows that if humans continue to be selfish, insensitive, and dishonest, both tales and human life will collapse. The village becomes a "hellhole" filled with rumours, sickness, and moral decay.

Thus, the narrative voice serves as a warning, showing how modernity, false stories, moral corruption, and disrespect for nature are destroying the traditional life of the village.

****

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR

03. On the Way to Goregaon – Summary (10 Marks)

"On the Way to Goregaon" is an autobiographical incident from Dr. B. R. Ambedkar's childhood. It describes the painful experience he and his brothers faced due to caste discrimination during a journey.

Ambedkar begins by introducing his family. His ancestors worked in the East India Company's army, and his father was a Subhedar in the British Indian Army. His mother had passed away, so Ambedkar and his siblings were taken care of by their aunt in Satara. Although she was physically disabled, she lovingly looked after the children.

During their summer vacation, Ambedkar's father, who worked in Koregaon, asked the children to visit him. They were very excited because they had never travelled by train before. Their aunt prepared food and made new clothes for them. A tonga took them to the railway station, and they boarded the train to Masur.

However, when they reached Masur, their difficulties began. No one came to receive them. The station master initially behaved kindly, thinking they were Brahmin children. But the moment Ambedkar revealed that they were Mahars (considered untouchables), the station master's behaviour changed completely. He walked away and refused to help them.

The children tried to hire a bullock cart to go to Koregaon. But every cartman refused to carry them because untouchables were not allowed to sit in or touch upper-caste carts. Finally, one cartman agreed but on the condition that the boys themselves would drive the cart while he walked beside it. After some time, the cartman left to have food and later returned. He sat in the cart due to fear of the dark but still kept distance from the children. The boys were frightened and cried, suspecting he might harm them.

Late at night, they reached the toll-collector's hut. Even there, they were not allowed to drink water because of caste rules. Hungry, thirsty, and tired, they had to wait until their father finally arrived and took them home.

This whole journey deeply affected young Ambedkar. He realised how cruel and inhuman the practice of untouchability was. The experience shaped his determination to fight against caste discrimination and work for equality and justice throughout his life.

AMBEDKAR COLGHRR

II. Short Notes

1. Ambedkar's Father

Ambedkar's father was a disciplined, responsible, and principled man who served in the Army of the East India Company. He rose to the respectable rank of Subhedar, which shows his dedication and leadership qualities. After retirement, he worked as a cashier at Koregaon, supervising the government's famine-relief work. Although he could not visit his children often due to his duties, he maintained strong communication with them. He carefully planned their journey to Koregaon and instructed them about the travel details, showing his care and concern as a parent. His values of honesty, hard work, and discipline had a deep influence on young Ambedkar. Even though he was physically absent during the incident, his presence is strongly felt through the children's efforts to reach him. Ambedkar remembered his father as a person who balanced duty and affection, and his disciplined background shaped Ambedkar's own personality and later commitment to social reform.

2. Ambedkar's Aunt

Ambedkar's aunt played a significant role in his childhood, especially after the death of his mother. She was extremely loving and gentle, but physically weak. She was a dwarf and had trouble walking, which made daily tasks very difficult for her. Despite her limitations, she took care of Ambedkar and his brothers with great affection. Since she could not cook properly, the children had to manage their own meals and often prepared simple dishes like pulav. Before their journey, she lovingly arranged food for them with the help of neighbours. Her emotional reaction when the children left for Koregaon shows her deep attachment to them. Although she could not offer physical help, her presence gave the children emotional support and comfort. Ambedkar remembered her kindness throughout his life. Her character represents the silent, caring women in families who support children with love, even when they cannot contribute physically. She added warmth and humanity to Ambedkar's early life.

3. The Station Master at Masur

The station master at Masur is an important character who reflects the caste attitudes of society. When Ambedkar and his brothers arrived at the station, the station master treated them kindly, assuming they were Brahmins because of their clean clothes and polite behaviour. However, when Ambedkar innocently revealed that they were Mahars (untouchables), the station master's expression changed immediately. He withdrew from them and hesitated to help further, showing the deep-rooted social prejudice of the time. Yet, when he noticed that the children were helpless and stranded, he felt sympathy and tried to arrange a bullock cart for them. However, even his authority could not convince the cartmen because none of them wanted to carry untouchable children. Finally, he came up with a solution where the children would drive the cart themselves. His mixed behaviour—kindness followed by discrimination—clearly shows how even well-placed people were victims of caste-based thinking. He represents society's inability to rise above untouchability.

AMBEDKAR COLG HKR

4. The Cart Driver

The cart driver symbolizes both the cruelty and helplessness created by caste rules. At first, he refused to take Ambedkar and his brothers because carrying untouchables would "pollute" him. He only agreed when he learned that the children themselves would drive the cart, allowing him to walk beside it. This shows how deeply caste restrictions controlled everyday life. During the journey, however, his behaviour changed. When darkness surrounded them, he jumped into the cart out of fear, forgetting his earlier concerns about pollution. This frightened the children, who suspected that he might harm them for their gold ornaments. Still, he continued guiding them and finally brought them to the toll-collector's hut at midnight. The cart driver also advised Ambedkar to lie about his caste to get water, which shows that he understood the harshness of social rules but still followed them. His divided behaviour reflects the contradictions of caste society—fear of untouchability mixed with human concern.

5. Water Issues and Ambedkar

Water plays a symbolic and practical role in Ambedkar's journey. Throughout their travel, Ambedkar and his brothers struggled to get clean drinking water simply because they were untouchables. At the riverbed, the only available water was filthy, mixed with mud and cattle waste, and unfit for drinking. Later, at the toll-collector's hut, Ambedkar tried to get water by pretending to be a Muslim, speaking in Urdu to sound convincing. But even then, the toll collector refused to help, showing how deeply prejudice controlled basic human needs. The children were forced to sleep hungry, despite having plenty of food, because they could not drink water. This helplessness made a strong impact on young Ambedkar's mind. He realised that untouchability was not just social humiliation—it affected basic survival. The denial of water became a powerful symbol of social oppression, and this painful memory stayed with Ambedkar throughout his life, inspiring him to fight against caste injustice.

6. Ambedkar and His Brothers

Ambedkar and his brothers began their journey with excitement. It was their first train journey, and they wore new clothes, carried food, and even bought lemonade at the station. However, their joy soon turned into fear and suffering. At Masur station, no one came to receive them, and after learning their caste, the station master and cartmen refused to help. The children had to drive the cart themselves, travelled through darkness, and faced loneliness and hunger. Their fear increased when the cart driver suddenly sat beside them in the dark. They even suspected that he might harm them for their ornaments. At the toll hut, they were denied water again because of untouchability. Despite all these hardships, the children remained united and courageous. The incident taught them the harsh reality of caste discrimination at a young age. This painful journey shaped Ambedkar's understanding of social injustice and influenced his future fight for equality.

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR

7. Social Injustice and Ambedkar – 05/10 Marks

The essay clearly exposes the cruelty of social injustice faced by Ambedkar and other untouchables. Even as a nine-year-old boy, Ambedkar faced humiliation at every step—at the railway station, on the road, and even when asking for water. The station master hesitated to help him, cart drivers refused to carry him, and the toll collector denied him water. The journey became a painful lesson about the caste system's inhumanity. Ambedkar realised that untouchability was not limited to school rules or daily restrictions—it followed people everywhere, even during emergencies. This incident left an indelible mark on his mind. It awakened in him the desire to challenge social discrimination. He understood that untouchability denied dignity, safety, and basic human needs. This early experience contributed greatly to shaping his life's mission to fight for equality, justice, and the rights of the oppressed. The essay shows how personal suffering became the seed of future social revolution.

8. Ambedkar's Train Journey – 05/10 Marks

Ambedkar's first train journey began with great joy and excitement. He and his brothers wore new clothes, carried delicious food prepared by neighbours, and even enjoyed lemonade at the station. They eagerly boarded the train and looked forward to meeting their father. However, the real hardships began when they reached Masur. No one arrived to receive them, and after revealing their caste, the station master and cart drivers turned away from them. The children had to drive the cart themselves, travelled alone at night, and faced hunger and fear. The journey turned into a painful experience of caste discrimination.
Despite the excitement of the train ride, the incident taught Ambedkar a lifelong lesson: untouchability followed people everywhere, even during joyful moments. The journey became a turning point in his life, awakening his awareness of social injustice. What started as a happy experience ended as a powerful reminder of the cruelty of caste-based discrimination.

III. What lessons did Ambedkar learn from his experiences at Goregaon? Explain. (10 marks – 250 to 300 words)

Dr. B. R. Ambedkar's journey to Goregaon as a young boy became one of the most important lessons of his life. The humiliating experiences he faced due to caste discrimination opened his eyes to the harsh realities of society.

First, Ambedkar realised how deeply the idea of untouchability was rooted in the minds of people. At Masur station, the station master spoke kindly to him at first, thinking he was from an upper caste. But the moment Ambedkar mentioned that they were Mahars, the station master's attitude changed. This taught Ambedkar that caste could immediately decide how a person was treated in society.

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR.

Second, he learned that untouchability denied even basic human needs. The cartmen refused to take him and his brothers in their carts. They were not allowed to sit, touch, or even pay for the service. Later, at the toll-collector's hut, they were not given even a drop of water. From this, Ambedkar understood that the caste system controlled every small aspect of life—food, water, travel, and social contact.

Third, he realised how people blindly believed in the idea of "ritual purity." The upper castes behaved as if touching an untouchable would pollute them. Ambedkar saw that this belief made people cruel, heartless, and unjust. He understood that such practices were not religious truths but social evils created by ignorance.

Finally, this painful journey taught Ambedkar the value of dignity and equality. Even though he was a child, he was treated as inferior. This experience made him determined to fight against caste discrimination. It sowed the seeds of his future mission—to create a society where all human beings are treated with respect, regardless of caste.

In conclusion, Ambedkar learned that caste discrimination was deeply unfair and that it destroyed human values. His experience at Goregaon strengthened his resolve to dedicate his life to justice, equality, and the upliftment of the oppressed.

In this essay, Ambedkar highlights:

The cruel effects of caste system
The fear of social boycott that controls people
The inhuman attitude shown towards untouchables
His own determination to fight for equality.

The experience strengthened Ambedkar's belief that society must change and that all humans deserve dignity, equality, and justice. Thus, "On the Way to Goregaon" becomes a powerful message against caste discrimination and a call for social reform.

Important Points for Exams

Autobiographical incident from Dr. B. R. Ambedkar's life
Shows the harsh reality of caste discrimination
Ambedkar and friends hire a bullock cart
Cart driver becomes fearful when he learns they are 'untouchables'
He jumps out and refuses to sit with them
Ambedkar and friends forced to drive the cart themselves
The dangerous crossing of the Kondgaon river
The cart turns upside down in the water
Shows humiliation, danger, and social injustice
Caste system treated people as inferior
Experience strengthens Ambedkar's fight for equality
Essay's message: Human dignity and social reform are necessary

AMBEDKAR COLG HRR